

Post-incident review PIR-2026-025

Payments API: stale data shown to users

Contoso Platform Engineering. Fictional sample data.

Summary

On 09 February 2026, Payments API experienced stale data shown to users in production (AU East) for about 75 minutes. The end-to-end checkout probe went red. Investigation found that a feature flag was switched on for every tenant instead of the pilot group.

Impact

Users of Payments API saw stale data shown to users for about 75 minutes. The service owner, Payments Platform, led the response.

Timeline

- 09:19 First signal received.
- 09:25 Incident declared and on-call team engaged.
- 09:44 Likely cause identified.
- 10:18 Mitigation applied.
- 10:31 Service confirmed healthy and incident closed.

What happened

Investigation found that a feature flag was switched on for every tenant instead of the pilot group.

Certificates were checked as part of triage and were valid.

The rollback script had never been exercised and failed on first use.

There was no documented procedure for this failure mode, so responders worked it out live.

The relevant alert had fired repeatedly the previous week and had been muted by the on-call engineer.

What went well

Responders communicated clearly in the incident channel and the status page was updated within fifteen minutes of the incident being declared.

Actions

- Assign a named owner for the component in the service catalogue.
- Add a circuit breaker and timeout on the upstream call.
- Write and rehearse a runbook for this failure mode.